The recycled air in the deploy pod hummed with nervous energy. Arbiter Nara, her crimson armor gleaming under the harsh fluorescent lights, sat perfectly still, eyes closed. The other soldiers, young and eager, shifted in their harnesses, their hushed whispers a counterpoint to the rhythmic thrumming of the engines. "She's got ice in her veins," one whispered, his voice filled with awe. "Imagine looking that calm, heading to the meat grinder of the frontline."

However, Nara’s mind was a million miles away from stoic serenity. With closed eyes, a frantic monologue raged within her. "Oh God, oh God, oh God. How the fuck do I always end up here? Deep breaths, Nara, deep breaths. Just like the shrink said. Inhale... exhale... Maybe if I faint, they'll send someone else..."

Another young recruit, close to hyperventilating, received a sharp elbow jab in the side. "Don’t worry, kid. You ride with the Arbiter. You’ll live through the day," the sergeant, a grizzled veteran named Jax, grinned, his teeth flashing white against his weathered face. The recruit forced a smile, looking over at the Arbiter.

“Are you ready to give them some hell, you little shits?” Jax exclaimed, and his men began their war chants.

"Ready as I'll ever be," Nara whispered to herself.

The silence stretched, broken only by the rhythmic hum of the engines. Then, with a jolt and a hiss, the deploy pod plummeted towards the war-torn planet below. Nara squeezed her eyes shut, her stomach churning. The legend of the unflappable Arbiter was about to enter the field, and all the Arbiter could think of was not to shit herself.

As the brake rocket engaged she could feel the pressure from the sudden change in motion, it was all too familiar, and then, like clockwork the pod walls exploded open, and all hell broke loose around them.